

Jesus Christ as the True Jerusalem: A Christological Interpretation of Psalm 137:1–6

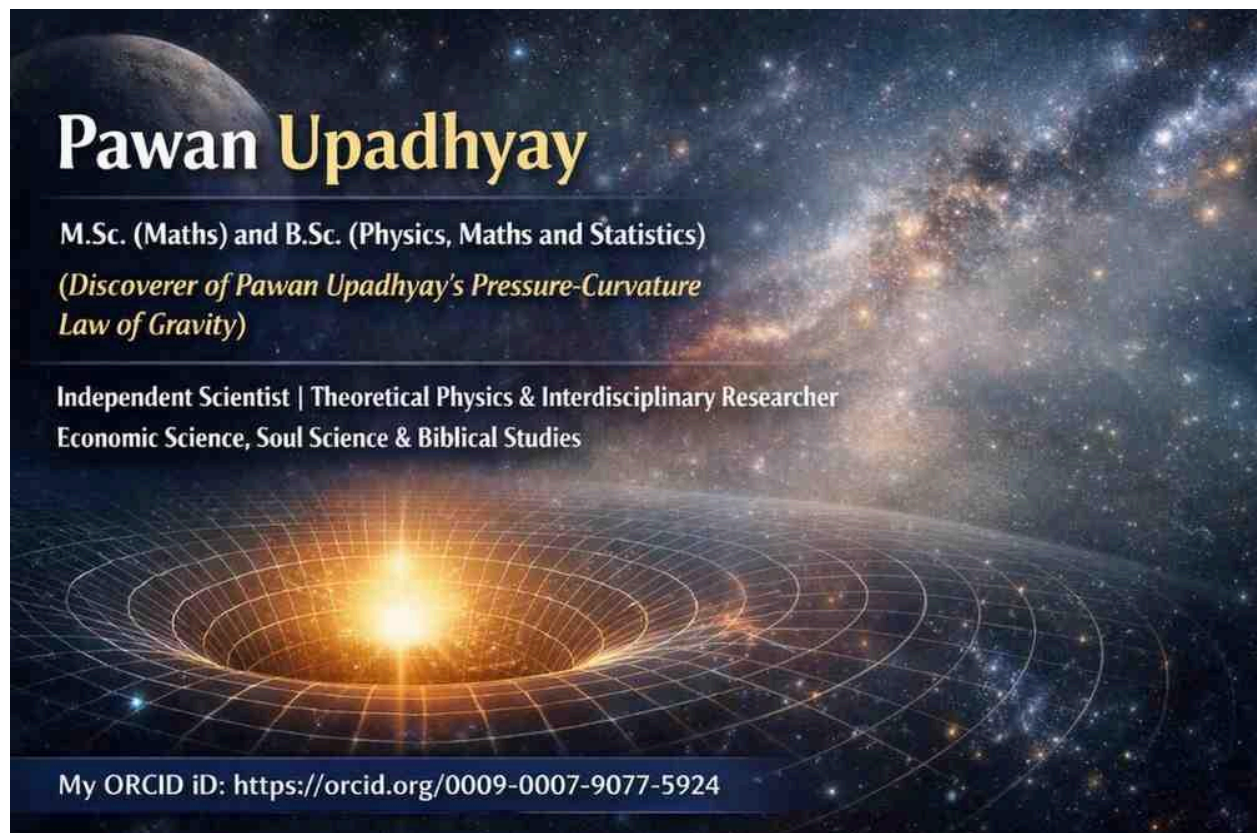
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Abstract

Psalm 137 is traditionally understood as the lament of Israel during the Babylonian exile, expressing deep longing for Jerusalem. This paper proposes a Christological interpretation in which Jerusalem is understood as a prophetic type fulfilled in the holy body of Jesus Christ. Just as God's presence dwelt in Jerusalem and the Temple under the Old Covenant, the fullness of God's holiness dwells bodily in Jesus Christ under the New Covenant. Therefore, remembering Jerusalem ultimately signifies remembering Christ, and exile from Jerusalem symbolizes humanity's separation from God before redemption through Christ.

1. Introduction

The Old Testament frequently contains types and shadows that find their fulfillment in Jesus Christ. Jerusalem occupies a unique place in biblical theology because it was the city chosen by God, the location of His Temple, and the center of covenant worship.

The New Testament reveals that Jesus Christ Himself became the true Temple and the complete dwelling of God among humanity. This paper therefore proposes that Jerusalem itself may be understood as a prophetic symbol whose fullest realization is found in the incarnate body of Jesus Christ.

2. Jerusalem as the Dwelling of God's Holiness

In the Old Testament, Jerusalem was holy because God's presence dwelt there.

Its holiness was never independent.

Rather,

Jerusalem was holy because God was present there.

The holiness belonged to God, not merely to the geographical city.

3. Jesus Christ as the True Holy Jerusalem

The New Testament reveals a profound transition.

God no longer dwells primarily within a physical Temple.

Instead,

"The Word became flesh and dwelt among us."

Likewise,

"Destroy this temple, and in three days I will raise it up."

Jesus explained that He was speaking about the temple of His body.

Thus,

the holiness once associated with Jerusalem becomes perfectly embodied in Jesus Christ.

His holy body becomes the complete dwelling place of God.

Therefore,

Jesus Christ is the true Holy Jerusalem.

4. Reinterpreting Psalm 137:1–6

Verse 1

The exiles weep because they remember Jerusalem.

In Christological understanding,

fallen humanity mourns because it is separated from Christ, the true dwelling place of God.

Verse 2

The harps remain silent.

Separated from Christ,

true worship cannot reach its fullness.

Joy disappears because communion with God is absent.

Verse 3

The captors demand songs.

Likewise,

the sinful world mocks the hope of believers.

Jesus Himself experienced ridicule and rejection before His crucifixion.

Verse 4

"How shall we sing the Lord's song in a foreign land?"

The foreign land symbolizes life in a fallen world.

Perfect worship belongs to communion with Christ.

Verse 5

"If I forget Jerusalem..."

For Christians,

forgetting Jerusalem ultimately means forgetting Christ Himself.

The believer vows complete faithfulness.

Verse 6

Jerusalem becomes the highest joy.

Under this interpretation,

Christ is the believer's greatest joy.

Every earthly attachment becomes secondary to Him.

5. Theological Implications

This interpretation establishes several theological principles:

- Jerusalem derives its holiness from God's presence.
- Jesus Christ possesses the fullness of God's presence bodily.
- Therefore, Jesus perfectly fulfills what Jerusalem represented.
- The exile from Jerusalem symbolizes humanity's separation from Christ.
- Returning to Jerusalem symbolizes reconciliation with God through Christ.

6. Harmony with the New Testament

Several New Testament themes support this typological approach:

- Jesus is the true Temple.
- God dwells bodily in Christ.
- Christ tabernacles among humanity.
- Believers become members of Christ's body.
- The heavenly Jerusalem ultimately centers upon the reign of Christ.

Thus, the movement from earthly Jerusalem to Christ reflects the progression from shadow to fulfillment.

7. Conclusion

Psalms 137 originally records Israel's historical sorrow during the Babylonian exile. However, its deepest theological fulfillment may be understood through Jesus Christ.

Jerusalem was never holy merely because of its geography.

It was holy because God's presence dwelt there.

In the fullness of time, God's presence became incarnate in Jesus Christ.

Therefore, the highest fulfillment of Jerusalem is found in the holy body of Jesus Christ, who is the true dwelling place of God among humanity.

The longing expressed in Psalm 137 ultimately becomes the longing of every believer for communion with Christ, who alone fulfills the holiness that Jerusalem foreshadowed.

Note: The Miracles of Jesus Christ in Jerusalem

During His earthly ministry, Jesus Christ performed several significant miracles in and around Jerusalem. These miracles revealed that the holiness and life of God were present in Him.

Among these were:

- The healing of the lame man at the Pool of Bethesda (John 5:1–15), demonstrating Christ's authority over illness and the Sabbath.
- The healing of the man born blind (John 9:1–41), revealing Jesus as the Light of the World.
- The raising of Lazarus at nearby Bethany (John 11:1–44), manifesting His power over death and preparing the way for His own resurrection.

These mighty works were not merely displays of supernatural power. They revealed that God's saving presence was fully active in Jesus Christ. If Jerusalem's holiness came from God's presence, then the miracles performed by Jesus in and around Jerusalem point beyond the city itself to Christ, in whom God's presence dwells completely.

Within the Christological interpretation proposed in this paper, these miracles may be viewed as signs that the true holiness associated with Jerusalem had reached its fullest manifestation in the incarnate body of Jesus Christ. The city served as the setting for many of these signs, but

the source of divine power was not the city itself; it was Christ. Thus, Jerusalem bears witness to Jesus, while Jesus fulfills the deepest spiritual significance that Jerusalem foreshadowed.

Author's Theological Proposal: This interpretation suggests that the miracles of Jesus in Jerusalem not only authenticated His Messiahship but also symbolically revealed Him as the true Holy Jerusalem—the living dwelling place of God's holiness, grace, and salvation. This is presented as a theological interpretation built upon New Testament themes of fulfillment, rather than as the literal historical meaning of the Old Testament text.

A Christ-centered (typological) reading of Psalms 137:1–6 sees the psalm's longing for Zion as ultimately fulfilled in Jesus Christ.

Psalm 137:1

"By the waters of Babylon, there we sat down and wept, when we remembered Zion."

Babylon represents the fallen world, separated from God by sin. Zion points forward to Christ, who is the true dwelling place of God. The sorrow of exile reflects humanity's longing for reconciliation with God through Christ.

Psalm 137:2

"On the willows there we hung up our lyres."

The exiles could not sing the songs of Zion while in captivity. Spiritually, apart from Christ there is no lasting joy or true worship.

Psalm 137:3

"For there our captors required of us songs..."

The world often misunderstands or mocks the hope of God's people. Jesus Himself endured ridicule, rejection, and mockery during His earthly ministry and crucifixion.

Psalm 137:4

"How shall we sing the Lord's song in a foreign land?"

The believer lives as a pilgrim in this world. True worship reaches its fullness in communion with Christ, even while awaiting the fullness of God's Kingdom.

Psalm 137:5

"If I forget you, O Jerusalem, let my right hand wither!"

In a Christ-centered reading, Jerusalem signifies Christ and His Kingdom. The faithful disciple resolves never to forget Christ, remaining steadfast in faith and love.

Psalm 137:6

"If I do not remember you, if I do not set Jerusalem above my highest joy..."

For Christians, Christ is the greatest joy and highest treasure. As Jesus taught:

"Seek first the kingdom of God and his righteousness..." (Matthew 6:33)

Summary

In its original historical context, Psalm 137 mourns Israel's exile and expresses a longing for Jerusalem. In the light of Christ, it can also be read as the soul's longing for Jesus Christ—the true Temple, the true dwelling of God, and the One through whom believers enter the heavenly Jerusalem. The Christian's deepest desire is to remember Christ always and to place Him above every earthly joy.

Note: The Meaning of Jerusalem and Its Christological Significance

The Hebrew name יְרוּשָׁלַיִם (**Yerushalayim**) is traditionally understood to mean **"City of Peace"** or **"Foundation of Peace."** Although scholars continue to debate its precise etymology, the element **shalom** (peace) is widely recognized as an important component of its traditional interpretation. In the biblical sense, *shalom* signifies more than the absence of conflict. It denotes wholeness, completeness, reconciliation, well-being, and harmony with God.

In the Old Testament, Jerusalem was the city chosen by God for His Temple, making it the center of worship and the visible sign of God's covenantal presence among His people. The city's holiness was not inherent to its geography but derived from God's dwelling within it.

The New Testament presents Jesus Christ as the fulfillment of these realities. Through the Incarnation, the fullness of God dwelt bodily in Christ, making Him the true and living dwelling place of God's presence. In this theological framework, the traditional meaning of Jerusalem as the "City of Peace" reaches its highest fulfillment in Jesus Christ, who is the Prince of Peace and the source of reconciliation between God and humanity.

Accordingly, this paper proposes that the spiritual significance of Jerusalem is ultimately fulfilled in the holy body of Jesus Christ. Just as ancient Jerusalem was holy because God dwelt there, Christ is the perfect and eternal Holy Jerusalem because the fullness of God's presence dwells in Him. This proposal is presented as a Christological and typological interpretation that builds

upon New Testament themes of fulfillment rather than as the literal historical meaning of the Hebrew name or the Old Testament text.